

1. Gulf of Alaska

Humpbacks make "bubblenets." They blow a curtain of bubbles around a shoal of fish. This causes the fish to cluster tightly, making them easier to catch.

2. Sea of Cortez

Humpback whales in the Sea of Cortez can often be seen breaching (launching out of the water) and slapping their fins and tails on the surface. Whales are social animals, and this behavior may be a form of communication.

3. Baja California, Mexico

The gray whales here are exceptionally friendly, approaching boats to let whale-watchers touch them and even scratch their tongues. The whales migrate between Baja California and Alaska.

4. Western North Atlantic

There are only about 450 North Atlantic right whales left. Most spend the summer feeding in the waters from New York to Nova Scotia. They head south in winter to breed in the warmer waters off Georgia and Florida.

5. Brazil

From June to November each year, more than 300 southern right whales gather off the state of Santa Catarina to mate, calve, and nurse their young.

6. Patagonia, Argentina

Orcas snatch elephant seals and sea lions from their colonies. They surge ashore on the surf and grab prey in their jaws as they land on the beach, before maneuvering back into the water with the next wave. If they misjudged the attack, they would become fatally stranded on the beach.

7. South Africa

Each June, southern right whales arrive off the coast of South Africa from their Antarctic breeding grounds, giving whale-watchers a chance to enjoy their spectacular acrobatic displays.

Whales

Graceful swimmers, superb divers, and powerful predators, whales and orcas (killer whales) are among the most impressive ocean creatures. They were once hunted near to extinction. Today, thousands of people take whale-watching trips to see these majestic marine mammals in the wild.